

POLICY BRIEF

Service Delivery and Clan-Based Social Protection Systems in Somalia

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This policy brief draws on our qualitative research and analysis of data collected through phone surveys conducted in four Somali districts: Adaado, Bosasso, Jowhar, and Marka.

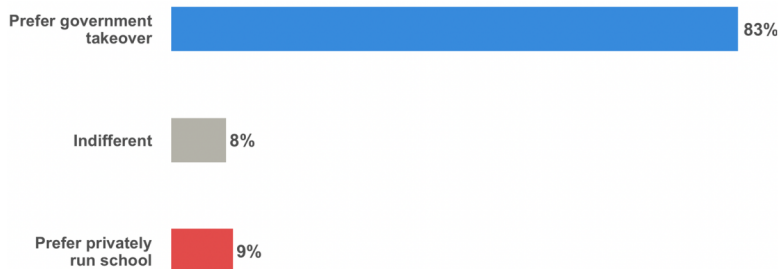
Our survey assessed civilian trust towards different levels of government, willingness to opt into government-led social services, and different aspects of clan based social structures.

This brief highlights the key findings from the survey.

CITIZENS THINK PRIVATELY RUN SCHOOLS WOULD PERFORM BETTER IF RUN BY THE DISTRICT COUNCIL

Respondents were asked whether the nearest privately-run school would support the community better, worse or the same if it was taken over by the District Council.

As shown in Figure 1, **83% said the school would perform better**, 8% said the same, and 9% said worse. While it is unclear whether District Councils actually have the capacity to improve school provision, we believe this shows that there is a desire amongst citizens to see the government take over social services that are primarily run by NGOs & aid agencies.



Survey data, Adaado, Bosasso, Jowhar, and Marka districts, 2026, n = 882
Results are weighted using inverse probability weights

Figure 1

RESPONDENTS ARE WILLING TO PAY ADDITIONAL TAXES FOR LOCAL GOVERNMENT SERVICES

62% of respondents reported a high willingness to pay additional taxes to support local government services. This suggests that citizens see taxation as a legitimate mechanism for funding local services, as well as something worth contributing towards. Notably, an adjusted Wald test shows support between men and women differed significantly at the 0.05 level, with 66% of men and 58% of women showing high willingness.

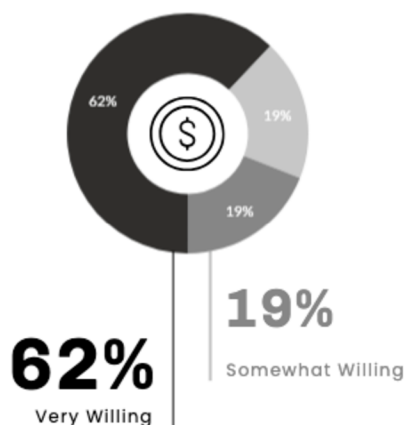


Figure 2

MOST RESPONDENTS EXPECT TO RECEIVE FINANCIAL SUPPORT
FROM THEIR CLANS IN THE EVENT OF A MEDICAL EMERGENCY

Respondents were asked about how likely the clan would financially support them in a medical emergency. Almost 75% of respondents stated it was at least somewhat likely they would receive support. In analyzing the two largest clans, we see that 80% of the “Biyomaal Clan” respondents say the clan is very or somewhat likely to financially support them in an emergency, exactly the same result as the “Habar Gedir” respondents. Neither differences were statistically significant.

Analyzing the results across all Dominant clans shows significant differences at the 5% level between the stated likelihood between Dominant clan members (79%) and non-Dominant clan members (72%). This could suggest that a safety net system possibly exists within some clans and provide emergency-based financial support as need rises.

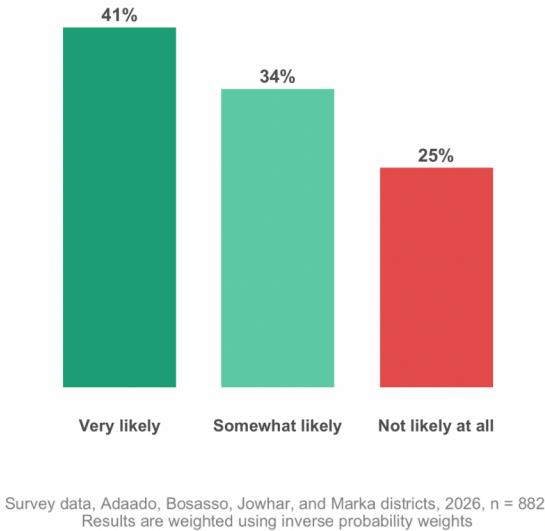


Figure 3

METHODS

The sampling method was a multistage clustered sampling process, stratified by district. The first stage consisted of recruiting households in person whereas the second stage consisted of randomly calling these households to conduct phone surveys.

The survey was conducted in March and April of 2026 and originally sampled 2,389 individuals, of whom 882 were surveyed. To address the low response rate, inverse probability weighting was used when testing the data results.

CHALLENGES

- Limited access to respondents due to security concerns. This created a speculated skew in the data towards urban and relatively safer areas.
- With only a 37% response rate, respondent bias is likely. We suspect citizens with stronger opinions on DCs were more likely to respond.
- We suspect some survey questions were misinterpreted or mistranslated, leading to potentially skewed results.

CONCLUSIONS

- Despite only existing for a few years, there are high levels of trust in the District Councils - significantly higher than trust at the federal level.
- Respondents stated a willingness to pay taxes for the provision of government-funded services.
- Clan-based financial contributions and support are not as regular as initially hypothesized. However, most clan members expect to receive financial support in case of an emergency.